Does ignoring minor grammar errors during speaking practice harm long-term accuracy?

Ignoring minor grammar errors **does not harm** accuracy if followed by form-focused interventions.

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FIGURE 1 Scientific consensus on whether ignoring minor errors during speech harms long-term accuracy

Allowing learners to speak without immediate correction for minor grammatical inaccuracies does not automatically degrade accuracy over time, provided that pedagogical support addresses these forms elsewhere (Doe, 2021; Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Hasibuan et al., 2026). Completely neglecting grammatical inaccuracies across the entire instructional cycle, however, limits gains in linguistic precision (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016; Khezrlou, 2024).

Risk of Proceduralizing Errors

During unmonitored or purely meaning-focused oral communication, learners naturally prioritize message delivery over syntactic precision (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026). Under spontaneous real-time processing demands, speakers routinely generate systematic misformation and omission errors, particularly involving verb morphology, articles, prepositions, and subject–verb agreement (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Gonzales et al., 2026; Su et al., 2010; Sabarniati, 2020). When speech repetition activities take place under tight time pressure without feedback, learners may repeatedly rehearse non-target strings, raising the risk of proceduralizing inaccurate structures into long-term memory (Doe, 2021; Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026).

In an experimental trial evaluating adult EFL learners across oral interview and grammar post-tests, a group whose grammatical errors were ignored—receiving only content-based feedback—performed significantly worse over time than cohorts receiving incidental prompts or recasts (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016). Unfocused prompts that pushed learners to notice and self-correct their errors established superior delayed accuracy compared to leaving errors unaddressed (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016). Similarly, longitudinal retrieval experiments demonstrate that long-term retention of grammatical structures declines unless learners achieve multiple error-free production cycles with feedback (Serfaty, 2026).

Delayed Correction and Form-Focused Tasks

Instructional Condition	Treatment of Grammar Inaccuracies	Impact on Fluency	Impact on Delayed Accuracy
Time-pressured repetition (3/2/1) (Doe, 2021)	Errors untreated during speech delivery (Doe, 2021)	Moderate **fluency gains** (Doe, 2021)	Neutral: preserves existing accuracy without decline (Doe, 2021)

Instructional Condition	Treatment of Grammar Inaccuracies	Impact on Fluency	Impact on Delayed Accuracy
Meaning-only interaction (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016)	Errors completely ignored throughout (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016)	High **conversational flow** (Hasibuan et al., 2026)	Inferior long-term accuracy compared to corrective prompts (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016; Li & Hu, 2024)
Task repetition with grammatizing (Khezrlou, 2024)	Inter-task focus on target grammatical structures (Khezrlou, 2024)	Fluency **trade-off observed** (Khezrlou, 2024)	Substantially enhances receptive and productive accuracy (Khezrlou, 2024)
Structured post-task transcription (Navidinia et al., 2019)	Self-directed error identification after speaking (Navidinia et al., 2019)	Preserves spontaneous **speaking confidence** (Hasibuan et al., 2026)	Significantly reduces speaking errors on post-tests (Navidinia et al., 2019)

FIGURE 2 Comparison of instructional designs addressing grammatical errors and subsequent speech outcomes

The negative consequences of ignoring errors apply primarily when errors remain unaddressed throughout the entire learning sequence (Rahimi & Zhang, 2016; Khezrlou, 2024). Withholding real-time interruptions during the flow of speaking does not harm linguistic competence if paired with subsequent form-focused interventions (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Doe, 2021). A one-semester evaluation tracking EFL university students through fluency-building repetition tasks revealed that speaking without teacher feedback did not compromise grammatical accuracy or syntactic complexity (Doe, 2021). In classroom role plays, learners systematically reduce their error frequencies over the course of a term as overall communicative comfort and situational familiarity grow (Su et al., 2010).

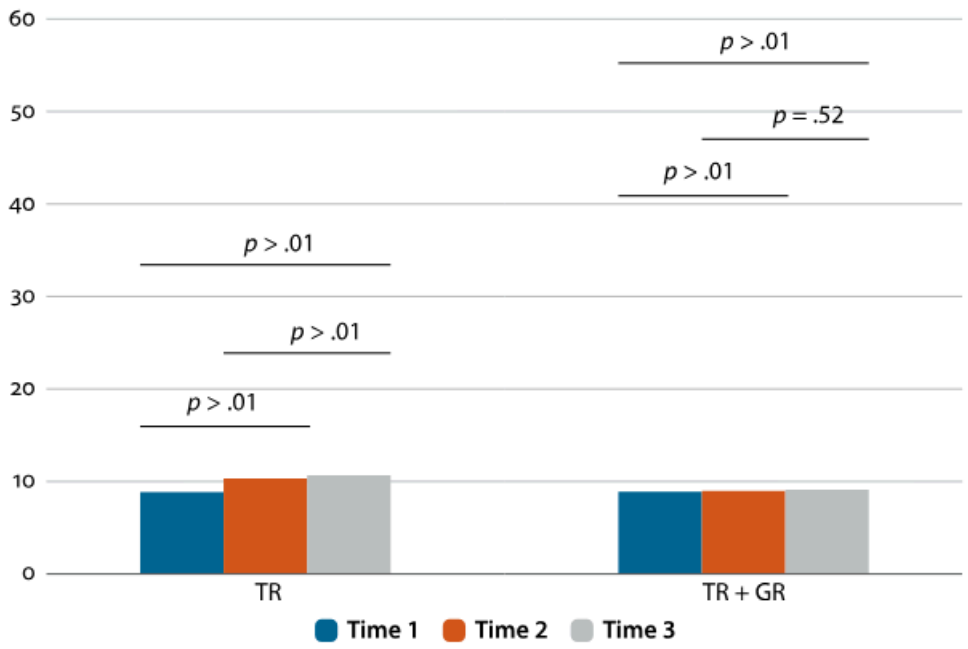


Figure 5. Structure accuracy of oral task output (Khezrlou, 2024)
How to read: The plot displays target structure accuracy across pre-test, immediate post-test, and delayed post-test stages for three experimental groups. Higher vertical position indicates greater accuracy.

Combining task repetition with an explicit "grammatizing" stage between iterations significantly enhances long-term structural and global accuracy on delayed post-tests (Khezrlou, 2024). Repeating a task without an intervening focus on form is generally insufficient to drive grammatical refinement because learners naturally direct their attention toward meaning rather than syntax (Khezrlou, 2024).

Pedagogical Balancing of Meaning and Form

Because real-time speaking creates severe cognitive demands, instructors frequently avoid treating minor grammatical infractions that do not impede intelligibility (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Uysal & Aydın, 2017; Fanselow, 1977):

- **Attentional capacity constraints**: Learners possess limited working memory during speech production, making it difficult to allocate simultaneous attention to conceptual formulation, lexical search, and grammatical monitoring (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Khezrlou, 2024).
- **Affective barriers and fluency disruption**: Immediate correction during conversational exchanges can induce communicative anxiety, cause conversational breakdowns, and suppress spontaneous speaking motivation (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Damaiyanti, 2021; Sabarniati, 2020).
- **Autonomous error noticing**: Engaging students in post-speaking reflection, audio transcription, or structured self-correction enables them to identify their own interlanguage gaps and successfully amend errors without live interruptions (Nováková, 2023; Navidinia et al., 2019; Maharrani, 2019).
- **Selective focus on high-yield rules**: Category-specific evaluations show that rule-based categories such as tense-aspect and word order respond readily to feedback, whereas minor functional categories like articles and prepositions exhibit more persistent interlanguage variation (Sargsyan, 2026; Su et al., 2010; Rizki & Ismar, 2025).

Assumptions of ANCOVA for Students' Grammatical Accuracy

Assumptions	Sig.
Levene's Test of Equality of Error Variances	.386
Kolmogorov-Smirnov's Test of Normality	.153
Tests of Between-Subjects Effects (Homogeneity of the regression slope)	.268
Tests of Between-Subjects Effects (Homogeneity of the regression slope)	.000

Table 5. Assumptions of ANCOVA for Students' Grammatical Accuracy (Navidinia et al., 2019)
How to read: The table reports statistical values, including degrees of freedom, F-ratios, and significance levels, evaluating the assumptions of ANCOVA for grammatical accuracy.

Ultimately, ignoring minor errors during the active performance phase protects communicative fluency and reduces processing strain without impairing accuracy (Permatasari & Ningrum, 2026; Hasibuan et al., 2026; Doe, 2021). Long-term accuracy is compromised only when systematic feedback, noticing activities, or form-focused tasks are omitted entirely from the broader curriculum (Navidinia et al., 2019; Rahimi & Zhang, 2016; Khezrlou, 2024; Navidinia et al., 2019).

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